Political Science 101 – Section 5
Introduction to American Politics
MWF 12:00pm, Turner 241
Spring 2026

Prof. Emily Ommundsen	Office Hours:
137 Deupree Hall	Monday 1:30pm – 3:00pm
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OBJECTIVES

This course is an introduction to American politics at the college level that is intended to serve both majors and non-majors. In this course we will discuss the origins of the existing governmental system in America and how theories of American government apply to current events and problems the government and citizens face today. We will work toward understanding our complicated and contentious political environment by exploring the system from two perspectives: political institutions, or the structure of the United States' government, and political behavior, or the actions and motivations of political actors.

It is my hope that you leave the semester knowing more about American government and politics, able to think critically about political interactions in contemporary American politics. Furthermore, I hope that this course inspires greater engagement in public affairs by connecting political science to live questions in American politics.

REQUIREMENTS AND GRADING

I expect you to be prepared for each class meeting having completed the day's assigned readings and bringing any questions you may have to our time together. I also expect your attendance at and participation in each class session. Evaluation in the course will be based on the factors below.

Three Exams (90%)

Four multiple-choice exams will be taken in person during class. The dates for the first three exams are as follows: Monday, February 16th; Friday, March 6th; and Wednesday, April 8th. The fourth exam will be taken during the final-exam period, which is scheduled for Friday, May 8th at noon. None of the exams are cumulative. I will drop your lowest exam grade, making each of the remaining three worth 30% of your final grade.

In-Class Participation via Poll Everywhere (10%)

As this grade indicates, a successful student will not only be present at every class meeting, but come prepared to engage with the material. I cannot make you come to class, pay attention, or participate in discussion. What you get out of this class (and your entire Ole Miss education) is up to you. To gauge participation, we will utilize an online quiz platform called Poll Everywhere. These questions are to be answered in class. You will receive a zero on this portion (10%!) of your final grade if you are found to be answering questions from a distant location. (Trust me, I have methods to determine if you are in the classroom or not.)

Poll Everywhere Instructions

This course will utilize Poll Everywhere through your smart device. I prefer you use a smart phone for ease, but a laptop or tablet will work, too. Instructions on how to register for and use Poll Everywhere can be found here: https://www.polleverywhere.com/poll-everywhere-student-guide.pdf. Please ensure 1) your Poll Everywhere user name matches the name on your Ole Miss ID card, 2) you create an account with your Ole Miss email address, and 3) you enable location services on the device from which you intend to answer Poll Everywhere Questions. This ensures that you get credited for your participation.

After creating your account, follow this link to register as a participant in my course: https://pollev.com/ommundsen/register. You must be registered to have your poll responses count towards your grade! Please note that you may not rely on cellular service and must have your device connected to Ole Miss Wireless. Be sure to do this for any devices you might use in class before the first day.

Poll Everywhere Grading

We will utilize two types of Poll Everywhere questions: 1) reading-assessment polls and 2) thought/activity polls. Reading-assessment polls will be conducted at the outset of most classes. These are intended to assess the extent to which students have read and understand the course material. These questions will be structured similarly to those that will be on the exams, so they serve as good multiple-choice practice. Reading-assessment polls will be graded as follows: 100% if you answered the question correctly; 50% if you answered the question incorrectly; and 0% if you did not answer the question/a response was not recorded. Thought/activity polls will typically be conducted during the middle of class. They will be graded as follows: 100% if you answered the question and 0% if you did not answer the question/a response was not recorded. Polls will be graded using this criteria beginning January 30th, 2026. This should give everyone ample time to navigate the setup and software.

Each day, one of the reading-assessment questions will be denoted as an extra-credit opportunity. If at least 80% of the class answers this question correctly, one person in the class will have the opportunity to take a basketball shot for extra credit. If the student makes the shot, the entire class will earn one bonus point on the next exam.

There are no opportunities to make up missed Poll Everywhere questions – this includes missed questions due to both absence and/or incorrect responses. I will drop the lowest 10% of everyone's polls to accommodate occasional absence, technology problems, athletic travel, lateness, etc. Please do not email me to tell me you were absent or your smart device was not working. We will have many opportunities for participation that missing one or two days in the semester will not affect your Poll Everywhere grade. If you have many absences due to extended illness, we will address this at the end of the semester with the necessary documentation.

Grading Scale

The criteria for how your grades will be assigned and how they should be interpreted are listed below.

Grade Letter	Points/Percentage	Description
A	93–100	Extremely good
A-	90–92	Very, very good
B+	87–89	Very good
B	83–86	Good
B-	80–82	High-average
C+	77–79	Average to low-average
C	73–76	Mildly subpar
C-	70–72	Severely subpar
D	60–69	Markedly poor
F	0–59	Self-explanatory

COURSE POLICIES, EXPECTATIONS, AND RESOURCES

Getting Help

I will post most of our course information to our Blackboard site and utilize Blackboard's messages feature. Please be sure to enable email notifications for course announcements. If you have outstanding questions after consulting our syllabus and the Blackboard site, please feel free to email me, stop by my office hours, or set up a meeting with me. When emailing me, please include "POL 101" in the subject line and I will do my best to get back to you within two business days.

Please do not feel intimidated to come to my office hours or set up a meeting with me, if my office hours do not work with your schedule. I am here to be a resource for you, and office hours are a great time to meet in a low-stakes environment. You are more than welcome to come alone or with a friend, talk about the course, ask questions before an exam, or just chat about the latest political happenings or college football.

Technology Policy

You will need to bring a device with internet accessibility (i.e., a laptop, tablet, or smartphone) to class to answer our Poll Everywhere questions. Other than using these devices to participate in this manner, technology is prohibited in our classroom for two reasons. The first is that many students do things besides taking notes on their laptops and phones during class, which can be distracting to you, your classmates, and to me. Second, research on learning has demonstrated that even the proper use of laptops distracts students and lessens engagement. While students using laptops may be able to take more extensive notes, the ability to consult these notes does not compensate for students' lessened classroom participation as they devote more attention to the taking of those notes rather than to what is happening in the classroom. Students using laptops do not absorb as much of the material in class, nor do they engage in classroom exchanges as frequently, depriving the rest of the class of their potential contributions. Other research shows that when students use electronic devices while studying, their learning and understanding is shallow rather than deep, and that they are less likely to do well on tests and assignments. Finally, research has shown that the process of writing longhand is superior for creating memory.

As technology is not permitted in this classroom, it should go without saying that the recording of any lectures or class discussions without prior permission is expressly prohibited.

Attendance
The University requires that all students have a verified attendance at least once during the first two weeks of the semester for each course. If attendance is not verified, then a student will be dropped from the course and any financial aid will be adjusted accordingly by the University. Attendance will be verified via Poll Everywhere responses.

Student Accommodations
The University of Mississippi facilitates the implementation of reasonable accommodations for students with disabilities, chronic medical conditions, a temporary disability, or pregnancy complications resulting in barriers to fully accessing University courses, programs, and activities. Accommodations are determined through Student Disability Services (SDS) for individuals with documented qualifying disabilities in accordance with applicable state and federal laws. For more information visit `https://sds.olemiss.edu` or email sds@olemiss.edu.

Academic Honesty
Academic dishonesty — including cheating, plagiarism, or any instance of taking credit for work that is not your own — will not be tolerated in this course. Any cases of academic dishonesty will be prosecuted to the fullest extent allowable under university guidelines, which can be found in the University's Student Academic Conduct and Discipline Policy and/or the University's Academic Regulations in the M Book.

Expectations
I expect all students to be have professionally and respectfully in this class. As one should expect of a course on American politics, we will often discuss issues of public contention and controversy. In order to facilitate a classroom environment that supports a respectful and critical inquiry through the exchange of multiple perspectives, we will embrace disagreement in the spirit of an open, deliberative democracy. Accepting the fact that constructive disagreement sharpens critical thinking and deepens understanding, it is not only encouraged, but expected. To encourage this robust discussion, please adhere to the following guidelines:

- Debate and discuss ideas, philosophies, and arguments, not individuals or groups
- Make attempts to listen to and engage with viewpoints that differ from your own
- Enter this classroom with humility, giving yourself and others permission to experiment freely with ideas

REQUIRED TEXTS

Lawless, Jennifer L. and Richard L. Fox. 2023. *American Politics: A Field Guide*. W.W. Norton & Company.

Your course fee gives you access to our required textbook for this class. You can find the eBook on our course's Blackboard page. Additional readings will be assigned throughout the term and can be accessed through our course's Blackboard page.

Additionally, given that this is a course about American politics and government, you should be a regular, informed consumer of news and current events. Below are a handful of reputable sources to find a variety of news. Additionally, I encourage you to enable notifications from these sources to stay up-to date on current events.

- *Washington Post* http://www.washingtonpost.com/politics/
- *New York Times* http://www.nytimes.com/section/politics
- *Wall Street Journal* http://www.wsj.com/news/politics
- *Politico* http://www.politico.com/

COURSE SCHEDULE AND READINGS

All listed readings are required, unless noted otherwise, and should be completed prior to the corresponding class for which they are listed. Readings from the Lawless and Fox textbook are listed as "L&F." Readings posted on Blackboard are marked **B**.

W 1/21	Course Introduction: Why Study Political Science? • Review the syllabus • L&F pp. 2–6
F 1/23	Why Government? An Introduction to Collective Action • Watch: "Rational Choice Theory: Collective Action Problems" (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=p3KlgxYhDbk) • Garrett Hardin, "The Tragedy of the Commons." *Science*, 1968. **B**
M 1/26	American Founding I • *Constitution of the United States.* **B** • L&F Section I, Segments 2–3
W 1/28	American Founding II • *Federalist 10.* **B** • *Federalist 51.* **B** • L&F Section I, Segments 5–6
F 1/30	Federalism • L&F Section I, Segments 7–8
M 2/2	Federalism: Contemporary Controversies • Steve Karnowski and Gene Johnson, "What to know about the looming federal ban on THC-infused drinks and snacks." *PBS News*, November 28, 2025. **B** – Skim: https://www.pewresearch.org/short-reads/2025/07/08/facts-about-marijuana/ • David Nakamura and Rachel Roubein, "Justice Dept. announces task force to fight overreach on abortion bans." *The Washington Post*, July 12, 2022. **B** – Browse: https://www.nytimes.com/interactive/2024/us/abortion-laws-roe-v-wade.html
W 2/4	Congress I: Elections • L&F Section V, Segment 32
F 2/6	Congress II: Representation and Organization • L&F Section VI, Segment 34

M 2/9	Congress III: Procedure • L&F Section VI, Segment 35
W 2/11	Is Congress Broken? • L&F Section VI, Segment 42 • Steven Pearlstein, "The Root Causes of Congressional Dysfunction." *Politico*, December 30, 2023. **B**
F 2/13	Catch Up and Review • Begin reviewing and bring questions to class
M 2/16	**Exam 1**
W 2/18	Presidency I: Formal Powers • L&F Section VI, Segment 36
F 2/20	Presidency II: Unilateral Authority • Nicholas Riccardi and Linley Sanders, "Americans think a president's power should be checked, AP-NORC poll finds – unless their side wins." *The Associated Press*, April 5, 2024. **B** • Rob Portman and Chuck Grassley, "Biden's student loan debt transfer is an abuse of executive power." *The Washington Examiner*, September 8, 2022. **B** • Aaron Blake, "Trump attacked Venezuela and arrested its president. Is that legal?" *CNN*, January 4, 2026. **B**
M 2/23	Bureaucracy • L&F Section VI, Segments 37–38
W 2/25	Budget and Appropriations • L&F Section VII, Segment 43 • Listen: Molly E. Reynolds and Adrianna Pita, "Can the Trump administration freeze federal spending?" *Brookings Institute*, January 29, 2025. (https://www.brookings.edu/articles/can-the-trump-administration-freeze-federal-spending/)
F 2/27	Judiciary I • L&F Section I, Segment 4 • L&F Section VI, Segment 39
M 3/2	Judiciary II • L&F Section VI, Segment 40 • Joshua Zeitz, "The Supreme Court Has Never Been Apolitical." *Politico*, April 3, 2022. **B**
W 3/4	Catch Up and Review • Begin reviewing and bring questions to class
F 3/6	**Exam 2**

M 3/9	**No Class: Spring Break**
W 3/11	**No Class: Spring Break**
F 3/13	**No Class: Spring Break**
M 3/16	Political Parties I • L&F Section V, Segment 28
W 3/18	Political Parties II • L&F Section V, Segment 33
F 3/20	Public Opinion I • L&F Section III, Segments 22–23
M 3/23	Public Opinion II • L&F Section IV, Segments 17–18
W 3/25	The Left, Right, and Middle? • Adam Hilton, "Despite Manchin and Sinema, Democrats are more united than they've been for decades." *The Washington Post*, January 25, 2022. **B** • Jeremiah Castle, Ryan Burge, and Paul Djupe, "Why young white evangelicals aren't likely to leave the Republican Party." *The Washington Post*, September 3, 2019. **B** • Samara Klar and Yanna Krupnikov, "Independents didn't decide the midterm election." *The Washington Post*, November 6, 2014. **B**
F 3/27	Elections I • L&F Section V, Segment 27
M 3/30	Elections II • L&F Section V, Segments 29 and 31
W 4/1	The Electoral College • R. Sam Garrett, "Electoral College Overview." *Congressional Research Service*. **B** • Garrett Epps, "The Electoral College Wasn't Meant to Overturn Elections," *The Atlantic*, November 27, 2016. **B** • Christopher DeMuth, "The Electoral College Saved the Election," *Wall Street Journal*, January 8, 2021. **B** • Optional: L&F Section V, Segment 30
F 4/3	**No Class: Good Friday Holiday**
M 4/6	Catch Up and Review • Begin reviewing and bring questions to class
W 4/8	**Exam 3**

F 4/10	Participation I • L&F Section III, Segment 19
M 4/13	Participation II • L&F Section III, Segment 20 • Optional: L&F Section III, Segment 21
W 4/15	Civil Rights and Liberties I • N/A
F 4/17	Civil Rights and Liberties II • L&F Section II, Segments 10 and 13 • Optional: L&F Section II, Segment 11
M 4/20	Civil Rights and Liberties III • L&F Section II, 9 and 12
W 4/22	University of Mississippi Campus Slavery Tour • Tour will be held during class time. Stay tuned for more details.
F 4/24	**No Class: Midwest Political Science Association Conference**
M 4/27	Civil Rights and Liberties: Contemporary Controversies • Adam Liptak, "In Narrow Decision, Supreme Court Sides With Baker Who Turned Away Gay Couple." *The New York Times*, June 4, 2018. **B** • Abbie VanSickle and Adam Liptak, "Supreme Court Backs Web Designer Opposed to Same-Sex Marriage." *The New York Times*, June 30, 2023. **B** • Optional: L&F Section II, Segment 16
W 4/29	Media • L&F Section IV, Segments 24–26
F 5/1	Catch Up and Review • Begin reviewing and bring questions to class
F 5/8	**Exam 4 at Noon**